

Notes and Queries

[The editors will welcome as contributions to this section of the *California Folklore Quarterly* either small items of traditional materials or inquiries designed to elicit information about such materials. In general, discussion of the materials here offered will be brief. Records of facts likely to be lost or overlooked, and inquiries which our readers may be able to answer—such items will be the typical ones.]

The Wild Girl of the Santa Barbara Channel Islands.—I was very much interested in Mr. Fife's communication in the April, 1943, issue (I, 149-150) about "The Wild Girl of the Santa Barbara Channel Islands." Allow me a couple of remarks.

In answer to Mr. Fife's question, whether any readers had heard similar versions, here is one that was told me in Santa Barbara in 1935.

This time it was the story of a man who had escaped from a civilized community to one of the islands west of Santa Barbara, preferring to live a wild, solitary life. I was given neither the reason nor the date. When he died, so the story goes, his relatives wanted to contest his will on the grounds that only an insane man would so take to the woods. The judge decreed, however, "that solitude and the desire for it do not necessarily constitute insanity"! I wonder whether this might not be a popular variant of the story of the Santa Barbara girl, with change of sex, plus testamentary embellishments. If this case really happened, there might be a record of the judicial proceedings.

As to her, I think she has little in common with such legends as that of Romulus and Remus. These boys were two of many abandoned babes, usually twins. For in antiquity when a woman had twins, that was considered proof positive of adultery, since one father can only beget one child at a time. Their lives were rescued by supernatural means, usually by an animal foster mother; their exploits spread through the folklore of many lands in many ages.

Then there are the modern abandoned babes, reported from India, Africa, and even Europe. Such unwanted children, when they survive, are usually sub-normal, if not irretrievably bestial. A few, abandoned accidentally, survive by their extraordinary wits; chief example in fiction, Tarzan. It so happens that I have made a rather elaborate study, soon to be published, of such folkloristic motives.

As to the Santa Barbara girl, Mr. Fife's story seems to be a rejuvenated version of the tale told, as the editorial footnote to his communication suggests, in the *Life and Adventures of George Nidever*. I might add that the story was

also told, on the basis of Mr. Nidever's, in an old, melodramatic French book by Ferdinand Denis and Victor Chauvin, *Les vrais Robinsons* (Paris, 1863), pp. 312-314, as "L'Indienne de Santa Barbara." As the title of the book indicates, it treats only of real people accidentally stranded in some uninhabited place à la Robinson Crusoe. Quite correctly the Santa Barbara woman was included, for she was involuntarily "wild."

As a matter of fact, she was not wild, in the sense, for instance, of the "wild children." On the contrary, according to Mr. Nidever, she was most tractable, even amiable, and always laughing. She had in common with the "wild children" only the fact that she was of unknown origin and spoke no known language; she had in common with the Robinson Crusoes the accident of shipwreck, whereby, stranded alone in a wild island, she survived through her ingenuity and resourcefulness, even achieving a certain contentment. Such cases have been rather common, especially in the age of exploration, as the above-mentioned French compilers prove.

The Santa Barbara man, on the contrary, represents the category of voluntary exiles. Some of them withdrew to the woods because of despair, caused by unrequited love. An example of this type was recently reported in *Time* (September 27, 1943, p. 40), "El Tarzan" or Pacifico Batista, of Itacuarare, Argentina. The photograph of this hairy wild man was reproduced in the same periodical (October 11, 1943, p. 32). Pacifico's is also an ancient motive; for its exploitation in literature see, for example, J. S. P. Tatlock, "The Lunatic Lover," in *Essays and Studies*, Vol. 14, University of California Publications in English (1943), pp. 43-48.

I suppose that a classification of these various stories might well turn on the meaning of "wild." I see three categories of wild-living people: (1) Civilized adults stranded accidentally in an uninhabited place, usually an island; greatest example Robinson Crusoe, with many descendants and even ascendants in both fact and fiction. To this category, I repeat, belongs the Santa Barbara woman. (2) Civilized adults who voluntarily take to the woods, because of love despair, like our friend Pacifico, because they are weary of civilization, like the Santa Barbara man. (We need not discuss here the pious withdrawal from the world of numerous medieval ascetics, martyrs, and saints). (3) Children exposed at birth or forsaken in infancy who survive by supernatural means, like Cyrus, Romulus and Remus, and countless others, or by their wits (Tarzan, etc.), or by chance ("wild" children of modern times). This third category presents, I believe, a far more extensive development in folklore than the others, which, however, often occasion and accumulate folkloristic elements.